includes producing and sharing online child pornography, which has now been rechristened across the world as Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) to name it for what it is. The agency identifies three basic forms of online child sexual abuse: sharing of indecent videos or images of children, the most prevalent type; online grooming, wherein an adult engages a child in chats about sexual acts; and asking a child to expose himself or perform sexual acts for live-streaming, or share a sexual image or video on online platforms. The CBI's findings that INDIA TODAY has accessed are a shocking revelation of such acts of sexual abuse and exploitation taking place across the country.

Both Gupta's and Victor's cases are among the 52 that the OCSAE unit has managed to investigate till now, identifying 60 minor victims and taking action against 133 offenders, including 14 direct abusers. As the agency found, they are truly an eclectic bunch. If one of the biggest abusers it netted, Rambhawan, was a lowly junior engineer in the irrigation and water resources department in Uttar Pradesh, it found the social profile of consumers of child pornography tracing an upward graph, right to the borders of elitehood. CSAM has been discovered on the phones/ electronic devices of an IIT student, a software engineer, a radio frequency engineer, a businessman in pharmaceutical distribution, a restaurant owner, an accountant, a mechanical assistant in a steel firm, an MBA student, a psychology master's student, and those pursuing various bachelor's degrees, and even one nursing diploma student. If the CBI had not come sleuthing, they would all be safely ensconced in their comfort zones, directly exploiting children, or deriving pleasure from seeing others do so.

The online bazaars of CSAM and the stifling real world where it really happens overlap at the edges. Victor had made contact with a potential partner in crime, also a resident of Tamil Nadu, via the Blued app. Introducing himself as Karan, Victor sent him a few videos that he said he had recorded, and threw a hook: the children were all from his village, he said, and if he chose to visit, he too could have sex with them. Victor was still at the start-up stage. Gupta had reached the second stage of expansion. Initially, he would send videos and photos to his friend Ajit in exchange for money. Soon, tired of being a mere consumer, Ajit started expressing his desire to get in on the act himself, and he too came down to Chandauli. Sessions followed with Deepu and Pawan, again video-recorded. This became like a drug for Gupta—a potent fix. He was having his pleasure, and mixing in business. Sure enough, that business instinct took its course: Gupta decided to expand his circle and earn more money. In 2021, he made contact with Avanish Kumar Singh, who ran a private institute in Chandauli. Avanish was in, and Gupta threw Deepu and Pawan before him. Many more dark soirees followed. Each one of them a brutal affair, tracing the familiar crescendo of spiked drinks, forced fondling, and all manner of oral and anal assault.

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

The netherworld of online child sexual abuse and laws to bring the offenders to book

WHAT IS ONLINE CHILD SEXUAL ABUSE?

- Sharing of Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) over the internet
- Engaging a child in online chats about sexual acts
- Asking a child to expose or perform sexual acts online

WHICH LAWS ARE USED AGAINST THE OFFENDERS?

1 PROTECTION OF CHILDREN FROM SEXUAL OFFENCES (POCSO) ACT, 2012

SECTION 14: Using a child for pornographic purposes; carries at least a 5-year jail term; at least 7 years for subsequent convictions

SECTION 15: Storage of pornographic material involving a child; 3-5 years jail term; 5-7 years for repeat offenders

PREVALENCE*

536 CASES

540 VICTIMS

2 INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY (IT) ACT, 2000

SECTION 67B: Publishing/ transmitting electronic material depicting children in sexually explicit act or inducing them for online sexual relationship; up to 5-year jail; 7 years for repeat offenders

PREVALENCE*

969 CASES

999 VICTIMS

3 INDIAN PENAL CODE (IPC), 1860

SECTION 293: Sale/ display of obscene object to any person under the age of 20 years; up to 3-year imprisonment; up to 7 years for repeat offenders

** NCRB's 'Crime in India 2021' report; these numbers relate to FIRs registered under the corresponding sections in 2021*